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Class Size

1 message

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Dr. Tamara Thomas Smith
 Superintendent

UPPER MERION AREA SCHOOL DISTRICT

Inspiring Excellence

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDENT

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March 26, 2026

Dear Bridgeport Elementary Families,

Thank you for your patience and for sharing your concerns about second grade class sizes this year. I want to take a moment to explain where things stand and what you can expect going forward.

Predicting enrollment is not an exact science. Each year, we use the best available data to project how many students will enroll at each grade level across the district. Even so, actual enrollment does not always match our projections, and those differences can affect class sizes in ways that are difficult to anticipate.

Each principal receives a designated number of staff based on total building enrollment. How that staff is deployed, including how many sections are created at each grade level, is a building-level decision. The current second grade homeroom classes this school year have had two sections. Students in special area classes are divided into three groups, which has afforded smaller class sizes (e.g., art, music, library, physical education).

The staffing plan currently in place at Bridgeport was designed by the former principal prior to his retirement. Dr. Grazel inherited that plan, which led to larger second grade class sizes than in other grades in the building. By the time second grade enrollment reached its current level, the window for hiring additional staff or restructuring classrooms had passed.

Staffing decisions cannot be made in isolation. They must be reviewed holistically across all grade levels, taking into account enrollment patterns, personnel, and multiple data points. A change in one grade affects the entire building.

I also want to address the question of whether changes can be made now. I understand the calls for immediate change. If there is a concern, why not act on it immediately? The honest answer is that making a meaningful change at this stage of the school year would create more disruption than it would resolve. Hiring a new teacher, reconfiguring classrooms, and dividing children who have spent the entire year building relationships with their teacher and classmates would be unsettling for students, particularly given that Spring Break begins next week and the last day of school is June 12th. Your children's stability and sense of routine matter, and uprooting that in the final stretch of the year would not serve them well.

We plan to make sure next year is planned thoughtfully. Dr. Grazel and all elementary principals are currently reviewing complete enrollment data for the upcoming school year and will make staffing recommendations to me in April. Dr. Grazel will design next year's plan with current data and your feedback in mind. I am confident he will communicate his rationale clearly and will be available to answer your questions as that process unfolds.

If you have questions in the meantime, please don't hesitate to reach out to Dr. Grazel directly. He is committed to keeping you informed.

Thank you for your continued partnership.

Respectfully,

Tamara Thomas Smith
 Superintendent of Schools